COLLEGE DE PARIS SUPERIEUR

Session 3: Oral Presentations

Bachelor 1 – Business English for IT Professionals



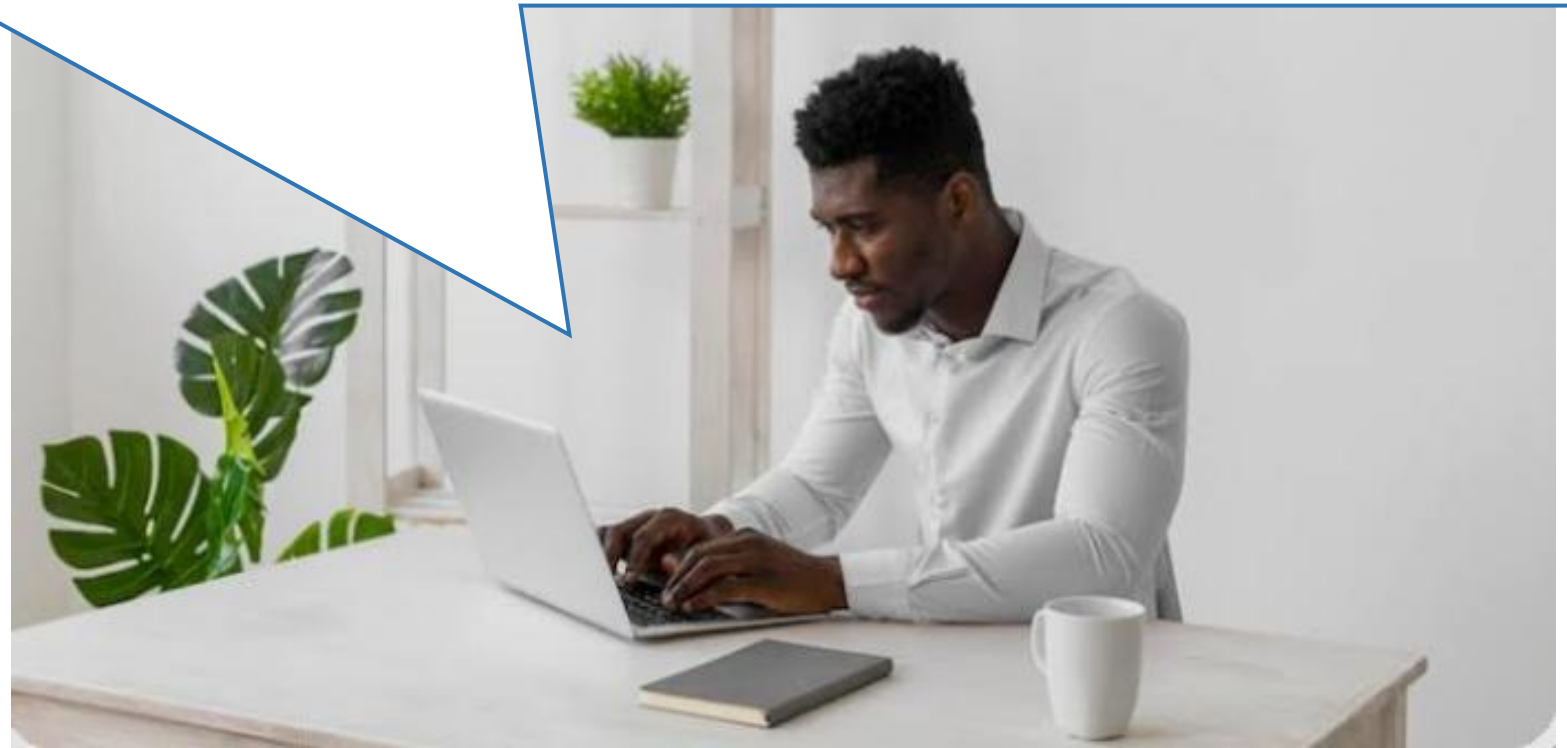
Dorcas Tchogoue

“The Presentation Panic”

“Present the server update to Mr. Tanaka. Five minutes. Tomorrow morning.”



“So, like, basically, the thing is, um… our backend infrastructure, which is, you know, connected to the, uh, frontend modules, might have, like, some issues.”



“Please, go ahead.”

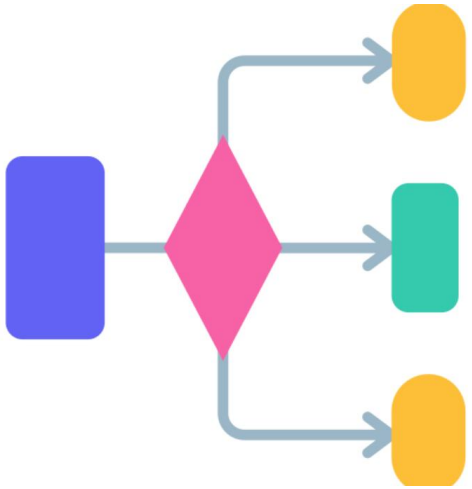


SESSION 3:
Oral Presentations in a Business Context

Objectives:

- ❖ Structure a 2–3 minute business presentation with clear opening, body, and closing.
- ❖ Use 5+ transition phrases (First, Next, Then, Finally, To summarize, In conclusion).
- ❖ Explain a technical IT problem to a non-technical audience using simple, clear lang...
- ❖ Maintain eye contact and use confident body language (avoiding reading from notes).
- ❖Handle basic Q&A with polite responses ("That's a good question," "Let me clarify").
- ❖ Give and receive constructive feedback using a simple rubric.

Goals



1) Every learner delivers at least one 2-minute presentation.
2) Every learner uses 3+ transition phrases correctly.
3) Every learner receives specific, kind feedback.

Why Presentations Matter for IT

- Explain technical problems to non-technical bosses/clients
- They don't care about code – they care about solutions

Discussion:

"When might you need to give a presentation at work?"

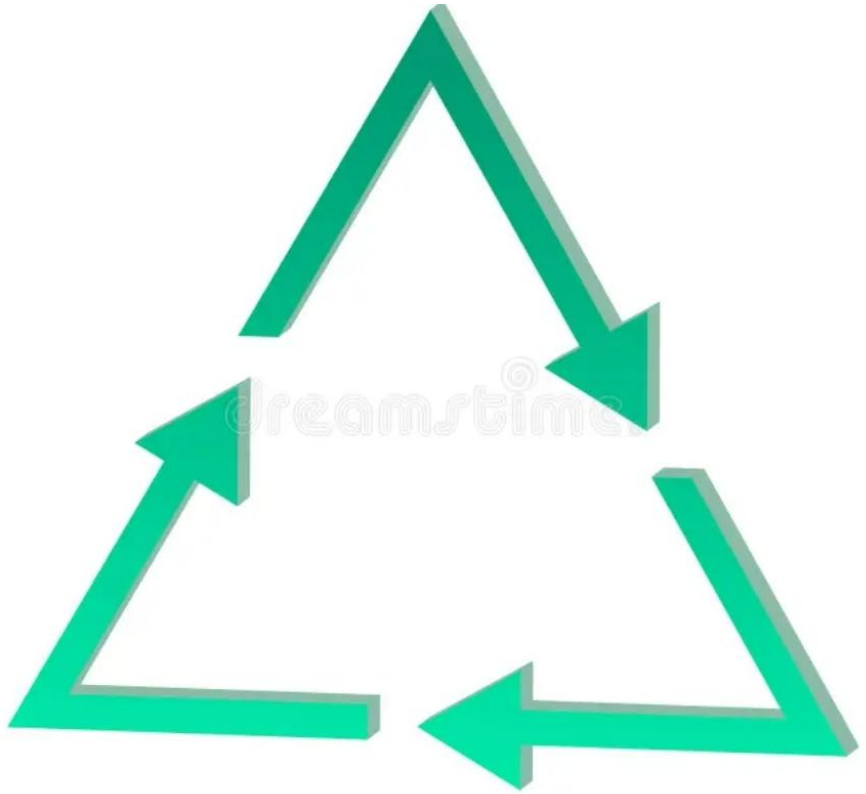
(Pair discussion – 2 min)



The 3-Part Structure (Simple & Powerful)

- **Opening:** Tell them what you'll say (30 sec)
- **Body:** Say it (1.5–2 min)
- **Closing:** Tell them what you said (30 sec)

Rule: "Tell them, tell them, tell them."



Opening – Hook + Roadmap

Hook: Start with a question, fact, or short story.
Roadmap: "Today I will talk about X, then Y, and finally Z."

Examples:

- "Have you ever lost an hour of work because of a crash?"
- "Today I'll explain the problem, the solution, and the result."

Exercise:

Write your opening hook (2 min)



Body – Keep It Simple (No Jargon!)

- **Bad:** "The API endpoint returned a 500 error due to a null pointer exception."
- **Good:** "The server stopped talking to our app."



Exercise:

Translate this technical sentence into simple English: "The deployment failed because of a CI/CD pipeline configuration mismatch."

Body – Keep It Simple (No Jargon!)

Exercise: Translate this technical sentence into simple English:

"The deployment failed because of a CI/CD pipeline configuration mismatch."

➢ **"The software release did not work because our automatic delivery system had a settings problem."**

Complex term	Simple replacement
Deployment	Software release
Failed	Did not work
CI/CD pipeline	Automatic delivery system
Configuration mismatch	Settings problem

Body – Keep It Simple (No Jargon!)

Exercise: Translate this technical sentence into simple English:

"The deployment failed because of a CI/CD pipeline configuration mismatch."

- **"The software release did not work because our automatic delivery system had a settings problem."**

Even simpler (for a non-technical client):

- **"We couldn't launch the update because the automatic system wasn't set up correctly."**

Very simple (The Grandma Rule):

- **"The computer system got confused and couldn't finish the job."**

Closing – Summarize + Call to Action

- **Summarize:** "To sum up, we had a crash, we fixed it with a reboot, and now everything works."
- **Call to action:** "Please restart your computers tonight."

Never end with: "That's it." / "I'm done." / "Yeah..."

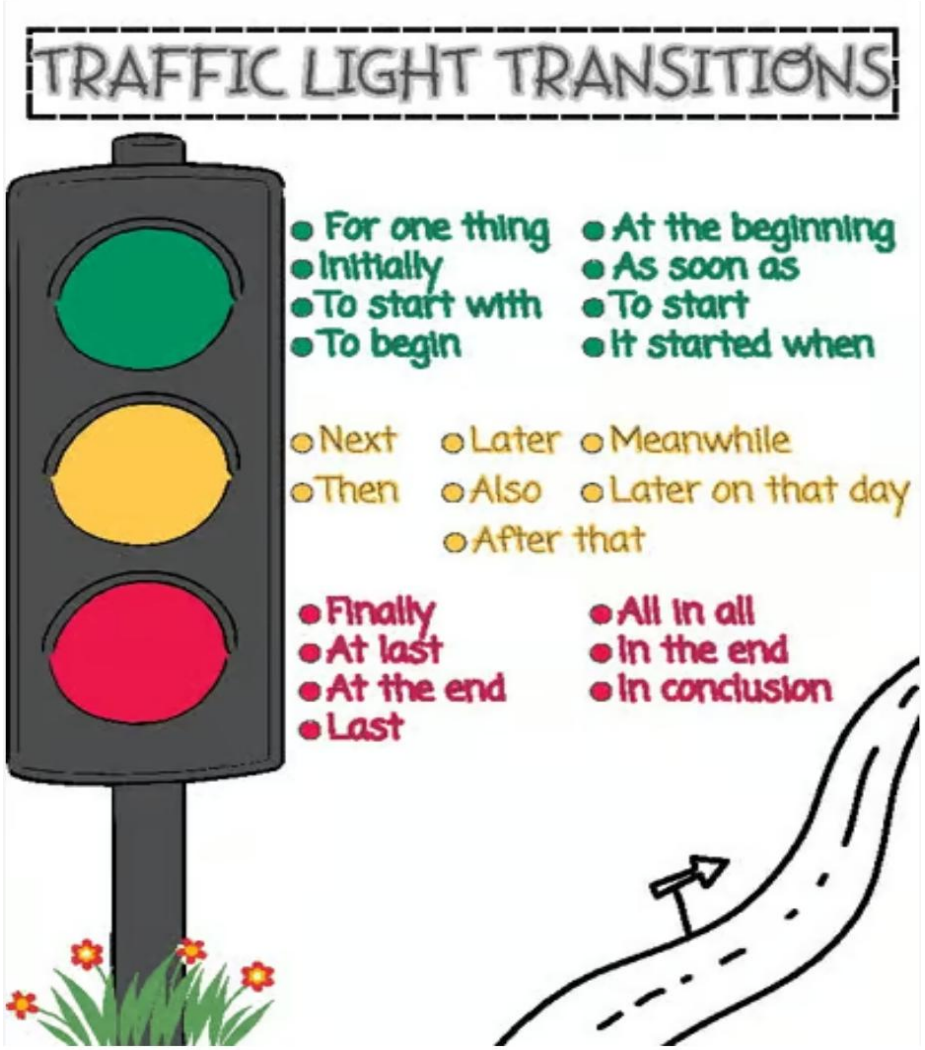
Exercise:

Write a closing for your IT problem story.



Transition Phrases – Your Best Friend

- Starting: "First...", "To begin with..."
- Moving on: "Next...", "Now let's look at.."
- Concluding: "Finally...", "In conclusion...", "To summarize..."



Exercise:

Add 3 transitions to your presentation outline.

Explaining Tech to Non-Tech People
The Grandma Rule

If your grandma can't understand it, simplify it.

- Bad: "We migrated the legacy monolith to microservices."
- Good: "We moved our old, slow system to smaller, faster pieces."

Exercise:

Explain "cloud computing"
to a 10-year-old.

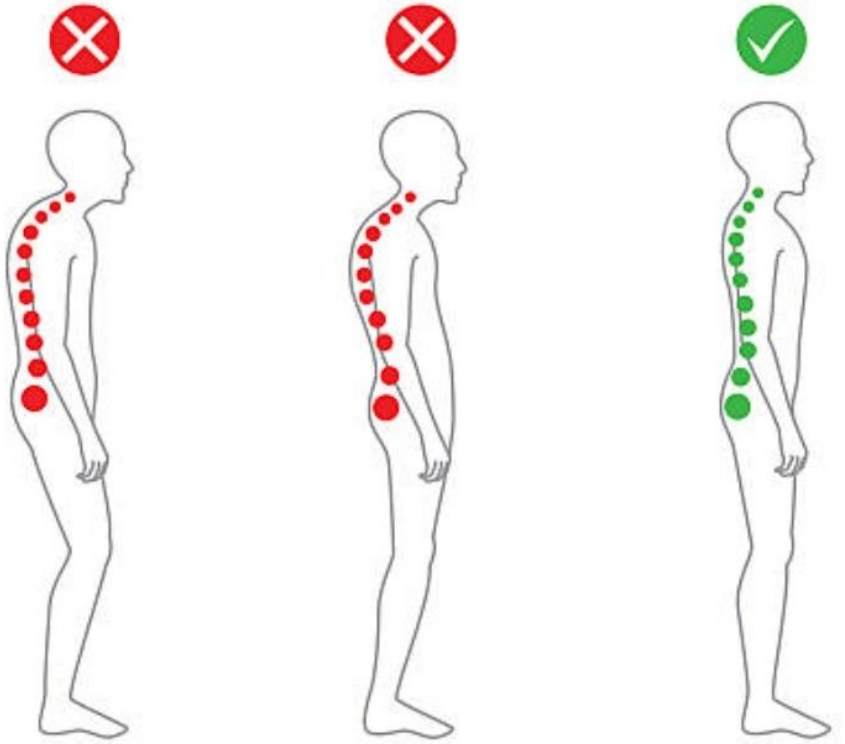


Body Language – Stand Like You Belong

- Stand up straight (no slouching)
- Eye contact (look at people, not the ceiling)
- Hands visible (not in pockets)
- No reading from notes!

Exercise:

Stand up and practice eye contact with a partner for 30 seconds.



Voice – Don't Be a Robot

- Speak slowly (nervous = too fast)
- Pause between ideas
- Emphasize important words:

"The server crashed, not the network"





Exercise:

Say **"The deadline is Friday"** with emphasis on different words – how does meaning change?

Handling Nerves – Everyone Has Them

- Take a deep breath before starting
- It's okay to say "Let me think about that"
- The audience wants you to succeed

Fun fact: Butterflies are normal. Even TED speakers have them.

Exercise:

3 deep breaths together as a class.



Q&A – How to Answer Gracefully

- Don't know? "That's a great question. Let me follow up after class."
- Don't understand? "Could you rephrase the question?"
- Never say: "That's a stupid question."

Roleplay:

Partner asks a tricky question; you answer politely.



Example Presentation – Bad vs. Good

- Bad: "Um... so... the thing... yeah..."
- Good: "Last week, our server crashed. Here's what happened, how we fixed it, and what we learned."

Class vote:

Why is the good version better?





Preparation Time – 30 Minutes

Outline your 2-minute presentation on "An IT problem I once solved."

- Opening (hook + roadmap)
- Body (problem + solution – keep it simple!)
- Closing (summary + call to action)





Presentations Round 1 – Volunteers First

- 3–4 volunteers
- Audience gives: one compliment + one suggestion
- No interrupting. Applause after each presentation.

Time: 15 minutes



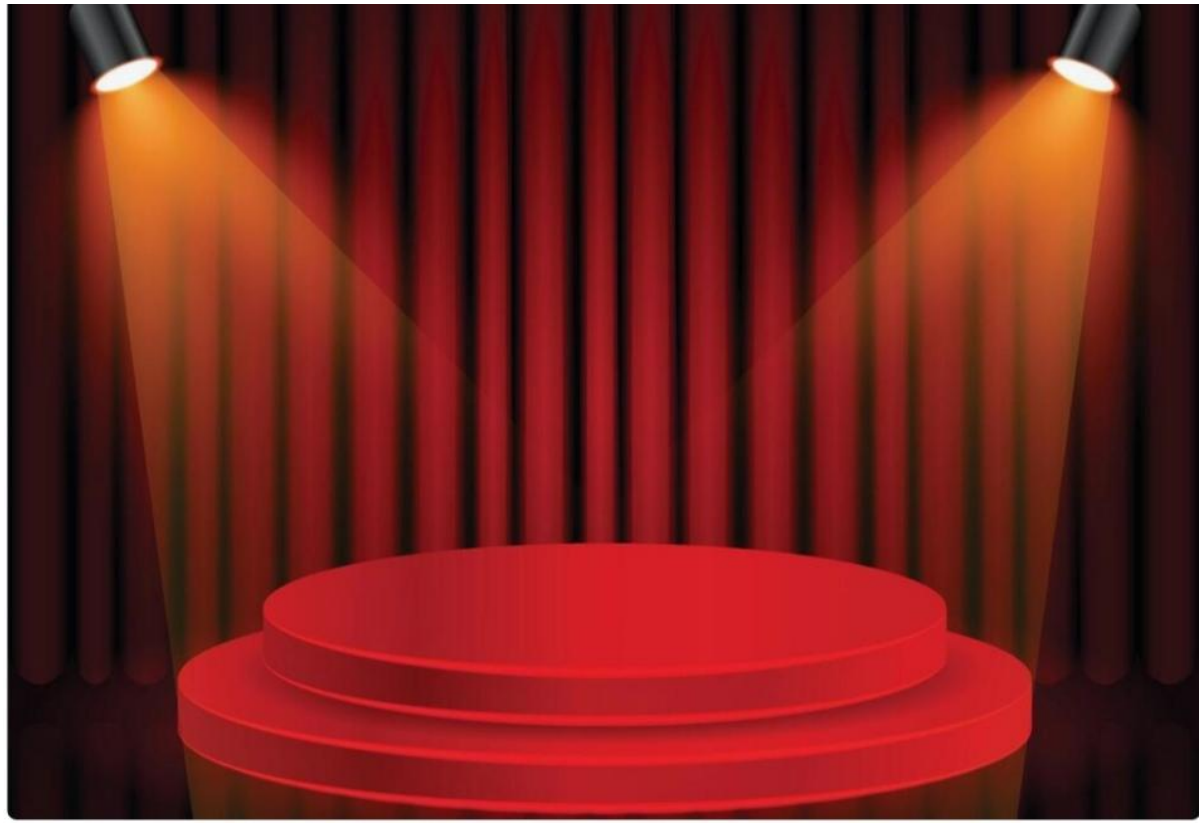
Feedback Rubric – Quick & Kind

- Structure (opening, body, closing?) – Yes / Almost / Not yet
- Simple language (no jargon?) – Yes / Almost / Not yet
- Eye contact (looked at audience?) – Yes / Almost / Not yet



Presentations Round 2 – Next Group

- 3–4 more students present.
- Focus on one skill only: transitions OR eye contact OR simplification.



Presentations Round 3 – Everyone Else

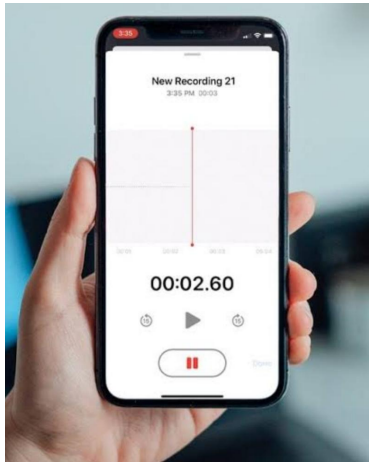
- Remaining students present (2 min each).

  Keep it low pressure – we're all learning.



Homework

1. Record a 1-minute voice memo answering: "What's one English sound you find difficult?" (for Session 4)
2. Practice your presentation again at home (in front of a mirror or pet).
3. Bring any pronunciation questions to next session.





Instruction: To be completed in your notebook before next class.
Note: This work is compulsory.
Students without completed homework at the start of class will receive a 2-mark deduction.

Session 3 Wrap-up

- You did it! You spoke in front of others.

"A presentation is like a pizza – even bad pizza is still pretty good."

Next session: Pronunciation & Fluency



Review and Reflection

- What have you learned today?
- Share one thing you learned and how you will apply it





Preview of Session 4 . . .

Next Time: **Pronunciation & Fluency Techniques**

- Practice word stress & sentence stress (REcord vs. reCORD).
- Learn thought groups & pausing (sounding natural, not robotic).
- Practice linked sounds & reductions (going to → gonna).
- Work on intonation for questions and lists (sounding confident, not unsure).
- Identify individual problem sounds (based on French L1 interference: th, h, silent e, -ed endings).

Some valuable resources:

Recommended Book

Title: Presenting in English (Heinle – Cengage)

Author: Mark Powell

Relevant unit: Units 1–4 (Getting started, Signposting, Visuals, Q&A)

Why: Focus on non-native speakers. Includes transcripts of good presentations.

Lighter Reading

Title: “How to present like Steve Jobs (but without the turtleneck)” (Blog post)

Source: TED Blog or Forbes (free online)

Why: Short, practical, fun. Students love pop culture references.

Bonus for IT students

Article: “10 tips for presenting technical information to non-technical people”

Source: Harvard Business Review (free summary) or Medium IT blogs

Why: Directly useful for future IT professionals.

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Thank you!



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